



Third Party Testing Framework

Version 2.0

10 April 2026

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Third Party Testing Framework

The Transportation Security Administration (TSA) utilizes a third party testing framework, in accordance with Section 1911 of the *FAA Reauthorization Act of 2018*. TSA intends for third party testing to supplement TSA test capabilities, and to increase a system's likelihood to efficiently complete TSA's testing process by increasing opportunities for early testing and therefore improving maturity of Original Equipment Manufacturer (OEM)-systems.

This framework is documented in the TSA Qualification Policy and Test and Evaluation (T&E) Guidebook¹ and briefed to OEMs and potential third party test organizations on February 22, 2018, at the TSA Test Options Industry Day. These documents and the industry day briefing were posted on the Federal Business Opportunities (FBO) website shortly after the industry day via the TSA Third Party Testing posting on the System for Award Management (SAM) (Notice ID 70T04018I9NAPM033). TSA also posted the Test and Evaluation reference documents on SAM to assist third party testers with test planning, execution, and reporting. Third Party Test (TPT) activities will be established as part of a program or project's test strategy created during development of its acquisition plan or Qualification Management Plan. TPT may be included in a project's plans for a variety of purposes, including but not limited to augment TSA in-house test resources, address specific system requirements, examine system updates, confirm equipment performance for acceptance, or provide an opportunity for vendors to mature their products before submission for consideration by TSA for inclusion on a Qualified Products List or Capabilities Acceptance List.

Third Party Testing for Systems Entering the Qualification Process

The third party testing framework for systems entering the qualification process is illustrated in **Figure 1** and further described in **Table 1**.

Figure 1: Third Party Testing Framework

¹ TSA initially published an appendix to its 2017 T&E Guidebook Rev 3 detailing the procedures for accepting third party test data. TSA incorporated this framework in the T&E Guidebook Rev 4 in 2019, Rev 5 in 2022 and Rev 6 in 2024.

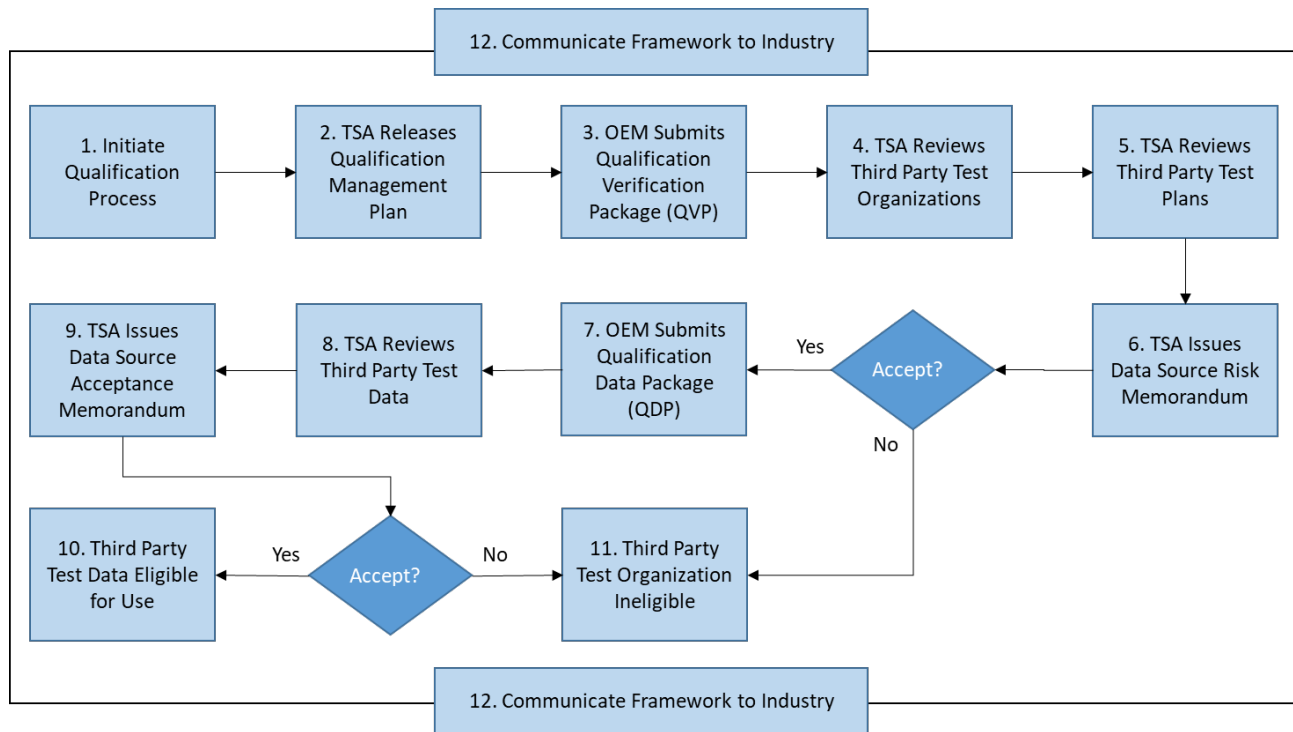


Table 1: Third Party Testing Framework Activity Details

Step	Activity	Activity Description	Reference
1	Initiate Qualification Process	TSA establishes a qualification process in support of TSA acquisition programs in accordance with the approved TSA Qualification Policy.	ID: 1 Title: <i>TSA Qualification Policy</i> Relevant Sections: <i>All</i>
2	TSA Releases Qualification Management Plan (QMP)	As part of the qualification process, TSA releases a QMP. The QMP encourages OEMs to utilize third party test organizations where appropriate, describes acceptable uses cases for third party test data, and provides additional resources to access third party testing information. - This plan provides the OEM with instructions on technical package submission. - TSA reviews this package to determine system readiness to enter TSA testing.	ID: 2 Title: <i>Sample QMP from the AIT Program</i> Relevant Sections: <i>2.3.9, 2.3.10, 2.7.1, Appendix B</i>
3	OEM submits Qualification Verification Package (QVP)	Any OEM requesting TSA consider third party test data must submit information on third party test organizations the OEM intends to use and associated test plans. - The OEM indicates the requirements for which the third party test organization will provide testing. - The OEM submits this information to TSA in the QVP. - The QVP is further described in TSAs Qualification Policy (Step 1 above) and in the QMP (Step 2 above).	ID: 1 Title: <i>TSA Qualification Policy</i> Relevant Sections: <i>2.3, 2.4</i> ID: 2 Title: <i>Sample QMP from the AIT Program</i> Relevant Sections: <i>2.3, Appendix C</i>

Step	Activity	Activity Description	Reference
4	TSA Reviews Third Party Test Organizations	TSA reviews the third party test organization information provided by the OEM against a set of criteria to determine whether the third party test organization is capable of providing adequate data.	ID: 3 Title: <i>Data Source Evaluation Spreadsheet</i> Relevant Sections: <i>Data Source Assessment Worksheet</i>
5	TSA Reviews Third Party Test Plans	TSA reviews the third party test organization's provided test plan(s) against a set of criteria to determine whether it is sufficient to collect the required data for the designated requirements.	ID: 3 Title: <i>Data Source Evaluation Spreadsheet</i> Relevant Section(s): <i>Test Plan Scorecard (QVP) Worksheet</i>
6	TSA Issues Data Source Risk Memorandum	TSA will document the results of its third party test organization and test plan review in the form of a Data Source Risk Memorandum. The Independent Test Agent (ITA) makes a determination of whether to accept the third party test organization based on its review and the level of risk presented in this memorandum.	ID: 4 Title: <i>Data Source Risk Memorandum</i> Relevant Section(s): <i>All</i>
7	OEM Submits Qualification Data Package (QDP)	Upon acceptance, the OEM submits the third party test data in its QDP. The QDP is further described in the TSA's Qualification Policy (Step 1 above) and in the QMP (Step 2 above).	ID: 1 Title: <i>TSA Qualification Policy</i> Relevant Section(s): <i>2.6</i> ID: 2 Title: <i>Sample QMP from the AIT Program</i> Relevant Section(s): <i>2.9, Appendix D</i>
8	TSA Reviews Third Party Test Data	TSA reviews the third party test data provided by the OEM utilizing the Data Source Evaluation Spreadsheet to determine whether the third party test organization collected the data in accordance with the plan and to determine whether the data show expected results.	ID: 3 Title: <i>Data Source Evaluation Spreadsheet</i> Relevant Section(s): <i>Test Data Scorecard (QDP) Worksheet</i>
9	TSA Issues Data Source Acceptance Memorandum	TSA will document the results of its third party test data review in the form of a Data Source Acceptance Memorandum. The ITA makes a determination of whether to accept the third party test data based on its review and the assessment results in this memorandum.	ID: 5 Title: <i>Data Source Acceptance Memorandum</i> Relevant Section(s): <i>All</i>

Step	Activity	Activity Description	Reference
10	Third Party Test Data Eligible for Use	Upon satisfactory test results per the above established framework, TSA will utilize the provided data for the approved verification, validation, or evaluation purposes, potentially reducing the scope of further testing conducted by TSA. The TSA T&E Guidebook documents all activities in this framework to support this determination. It also provides instructions for using the Data Source Evaluation Spreadsheet.	ID: 6 Title: <i>Test and Evaluation Guidebook</i> Relevant Section(s): 3.4, Appendix F
11	Third Party Test Organization Ineligible	Upon assessment against acceptance criteria, TSA may determine the third party test organization, test plan, and/or test data is inadequate for use in its system evaluation. In this case, TSA will not consider the third party test organization and any provided test data.	ID: 6 Title: <i>Test and Evaluation Guidebook</i> Relevant Section(s): 3.4, Appendix F
12	Communicate Framework to Industry	As previously discussed, senior TSA officials briefed the third party testing framework to OEMs and potential third party test organizations on February 22, 2018, during the TSA Test Options Industry Day. TSA then posted industry day slides and additional relevant materials to SAM in early 2018 and are available today. TSA references these materials when possible in qualification process documentation.	ID: 7 Title: <i>TSA Test Options Industry Day Slides</i> Relevant Section(s): All

Third Party Testing for Systems Encountering Failures once in the Qualification Process

Upon encountering deficiencies during TSA testing, depending on the specifics of the QMP, an OEM may be required to demonstrate to TSA that the deficiencies have been corrected prior to re-entry into the TSA testing process. TSA documents the procedures for re-entry in the system-specific QMP (**Table 1, Step 2**), which may include third party test verification.

Table 2: Reference Documents

ID	Title	Date Signed/Final	Attachment
1	TSA Qualification Policy	1/9/2018	 TSA Qualification Policy (FINAL)
2	Sample QMP from the Advanced Imaging Technology Program	12/4/2020	 AIT-2 Qualification Mgmt Plan
3	Data Source Evaluation Spreadsheet	4/27/2018	 Data Source Evaluation
4	Data Source Risk Memorandum	12/4/2019	 Data Source Risk Memo Template
5	Data Source Acceptance Memorandum	12/4/2019	 Data Source Acceptance Memo T
6	Test and Evaluation Guidebook, Revision 6	8/27/2024	 20240827 -TSA T&E Guidebook Rev 6 - F
7	TSA Test Options Industry Day Slides	2/22/2018	 T&E Industry Day (T&E Options)

How TSA's Third Party Testing Framework Satisfies Section 1911 of the FAA Reauthorization Act

Table 3 lists core elements of Section 1911, Third Party Testing and Verification of Screening Technology of the Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) Reauthorization Act. For each of the listed elements, TSA describes how its third party testing framework satisfies the guidance.

Table 3: FAA Reauthorization Act Alignment to TSA's Third Party Testing Framework

Part	Paraphrased Guidance	Third Party Testing Framework
a	...shall develop and implement, not later than 1 year after the date of enactment of this Act, a program to enable a vendor of related security screening technology to obtain testing ...	• Upon successful review of the third party test organization, test plan, and test results, TSA will consider the test data in its evaluation and will reduce its required testing accordingly. • TSA implemented this framework in February of 2018 (prior to finalization of the FAA Reauthorization Act).
b(1)	...shall include detection testing to evaluate the performance of the security screening technology system ...	TSA does not restrict the type of third party data it will review, score, and possibly accept.
b(2)	...shall be considered final if the results are approved by the Administration...	The ITA can consider detection test data for acceptance after approval of the third party test organization, test plan, and test data per the established criteria. Criteria communicated at the Test Options Industry Day and posted to SAM.
b(3)	...without compromising the integrity of the TSA test and evaluation process, the Administrator shall coordinate the third party detection testing with any subsequent, final Federal Government testing...	• TSA retains the authority to use accepted third party test data in lieu of the TSA test activity or in some cases, to supplement but not replace the test activity. • Some level of final Federal Government testing may be required for some evaluation areas (e.g., Key Performance Parameters).
b(4)	...share detection testing information and standards with appropriate international partners...coordinate with the appropriate international partners to align TSA testing and evaluation with relevant international standards...	Coordination with international partners is not within the scope of the third party testing framework.
c (1)(2)	...the third party testing and verification program...shall include operational testing. Third party operational testing...may not exceed 1 year.	• The framework allows the OEM to select requirements for third party test substantiation that are evaluated in the operational environment to include throughput and reliability, maintainability, and availability. • Upon acceptance, the ITA can utilize this data as a supplemental data source to the required independent TSA operational test. • TSA published templates of its Operational Test Plan, Data Collection Activity Report, System Evaluation Report, and other documents to assist an OEM in third party operational testing.

Part	Paraphrased Guidance	Third Party Testing Framework
d (1-7)	...shall replace as an alternative, at the discretion of the Administrator, the testing at the TSA Systems Integration Facility, including testing for...areas listed.	• TSA does not restrict the type of third party data it will review, score, and possibly accept. Data accepted by the ITA can be used to support the system evaluation and reduce the scope of testing at the TSA Systems Integration Facility. • Requirements under all areas listed are eligible for OEMs to consider under the third party testing framework.
e(1)	...shall establish a framework for the third party testing and for verifying a security technology is operationally effective...	See third party testing framework in Figure 1 and Table 1. TSA has documented this framework in the TSA T&E Guidebook and shared with industry.
e(2)	...shall request ASAC's Security Technology Subcommittee, in consultation with representatives of the security manufacturers industry, to develop and submit to the Administrator recommendations...	• TSA extensively interfaced with the Security Manufacturer's Coalition in review of the industry day slides for third party testing, T&E Guidebook content and in reviewing TSA's Qualification Process. • Security Manufacturer's Coalition representatives were in attendance for the industry day (date coordinated to ensure they could attend). • TSA reviews and implements (when appropriate) recommendations received from the ASAC.
f	...shall prioritize the field testing and evaluation, including by third parties, of security technology and equipment...as an alternative to the TSA Systems Integration Facility.	• As introduced in the TSA Qualification Policy, the Framework focuses on early testing, prior to any testing at the TSA Systems Integration Facility. • The third party testing is prioritized in these early stages to potentially reduce future TSA testing. Development of all future test plans will consider any test data from approved third party test organizations.
g (1)(2)	...an appropriate third party... shall be if an individual, a citizen of the United States; or if an entity, owned and controlled by a citizen of the United States...	TSA will assess a third party test organization's entity/ownership citizenship status upon initial submission during the QVP step of the framework.
g(3)	The Administrator shall ensure... an entity providing third party testing under this section does not have a contractual, business, or other pecuniary interest...	TSA will assess a third party test organization for Organizational Conflict of Interest upon initial submission during the QVP step of the framework.
h(all)	Government Accountability Office Review	• TSA fully supported the 2100.5 Government Accountability Office 103957 review of the TSA Third Party Testing Program culminating with a final report and three action items that TSA accepted. • As a result of this review, one action item has successfully closed while TSA continues to periodically report status on the other two items.